

Inversion

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

Each sentence contains TWO errors. Proofread the sentences.

Social media connects people instantly which make the world feel smaller.
Online courses are ideal for busy adults, especially those which has little time to attend classes.
There are dozens of messaging apps, all of them is free to use.
The forums which students share their homework is very popular.
Many teenagers spend hours gaming, that worry their parents.
Not only the internet connects people around the world, but it also spreads information quickly.

Teacher's answers

Item	Correction (fix both errors)
1	Social media connects people instantly, which makes the world feel smaller. (Add the comma; make → makes — the clause refers to the whole idea.)
2	Online courses are ideal for busy adults, especially those who have little time to attend classes. (which → who; has → have.)
3	There are dozens of messaging apps, all of which are free to use. (them → which; is → are.)
4	Teacher's Answer A: The forums on which students share their homework are very popular. Teacher's Answer B: The forums where students share their homework are very popular. (Add on; is → are.)
5	Many teenagers spend hours gaming, which worries their parents. (that → which — connective clause; worry → worries.)
6	Not only does the internet connect people around the world, but it also spreads information quickly. (Add does before the subject; connects → connect.)

Part 2: Three patterns for formal writing

The three patterns in this part all follow the same rule: the auxiliary verb (or the verb 'be') moves before the subject. Each pattern can lift a formal paragraph towards a higher band.

Pattern 1: Not only ... but also ...

Structure:	Not only + auxiliary + subject + verb, but (subject) also + verb
Use in formal writing:	Adds a second advantage in proposals, reports and articles.
Example:	Not only does the scheme save money, but it also builds students' confidence.

Introducing a school e-learning platform would bring clear benefits. Not only does the platform give students round-the-clock access to learning materials, but it also allows teachers to track progress more closely. With such a system, revision becomes a habit rather than a scramble before exams.

Pattern 2: Never / Rarely / Seldom

Structure:	Never / Rarely / Seldom + auxiliary + subject + verb
Use in formal writing:	Makes a criticism or a claim sound stronger and more formal.
Example:	Rarely do we question our daily screen habits.

Many parents blame video games for every poor result. Rarely do they stop to consider how limited their children's other entertainment options are. The real problem may be the lack of balance, not the games themselves.

Pattern 3: Only by ...

Structure:	Only by + -ing / noun phrase + auxiliary + subject + verb
Use in formal writing:	Sets a condition that leads to a result — ideal for conclusions and recommendations.

Example:	Only by upgrading the campus network can the school offer reliable online lessons.
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Working from home has become common in many industries. Only by investing in secure networks and clear communication tools can companies keep their teams productive. Technology can help, but good management matters more.

Additional pattern (teacher's note — optional)

Introduce this only after the class is secure with the three core patterns. The mechanism is the same: front the expression, then place the auxiliary before the subject.

So ... that / Such ... that

Structure:	So + adjective + auxiliary + subject + verb + that ... OR Such + be + noun phrase + that ...
Example:	Such is the influence of social media that it shapes public opinion overnight.
Use:	Use it to open with a strong statement when emphasising the scale or importance of an issue.

You can also extend Pattern 3 with 'Only when ...' or 'Only after ...' for stronger classes.

Part 3: Practice sets

Rewrite each simple sentence using the pattern given in the prompt. The sentences are all about technology and communication, so keep the register formal. The even-numbered sets (2, 4 and 6) are more challenging.

Example Set 1 (Not only ... but also ...)

Simple sentence:	The online platform saves paper, and it gives students instant feedback.
Prompt:	<i>Begin with 'Not only' to add a second advantage.</i>
Teacher's Answer:	Not only does the online platform save paper, but it also gives students instant feedback.

Example Set 2 (Not only ... but also ...)

Simple sentence:	The workshop improved students' digital skills, and it boosted their confidence in online presentations.
Prompt:	Use 'Not only ... but also ...' to combine the workshop's two benefits.
Teacher's Answer:	Not only did the workshop improve students' digital skills, but it also boosted their confidence in online presentations.

Example Set 3 (Never / Rarely / Seldom)

Simple sentence:	Parents don't really check what their children are doing online.
Prompt:	Begin with 'Rarely'.
Teacher's Answer:	Rarely do parents really check what their children are doing online.

Example Set 4 (Never / Rarely / Seldom)

Simple sentence:	People rarely question headline claims, and they should not trust unverified rumors.
Prompt:	Begin with 'Never'.
Teacher's Answer:	Never should people trust unverified rumors, and rarely do they question headline claims. (Alternative: People rarely question headline claims, and never should they trust unverified rumors.)

Example Set 5 (Only by ...)

Simple sentence:	Schools can protect students' privacy if they issue clear guidelines on social media use.
Prompt:	Begin with 'Only by'.
Teacher's Answer:	Only by issuing clear guidelines on social media use can schools protect students' privacy.

Example Set 6 (Only by ...)

Simple sentence:	If we want to fight online scams, governments should work closely with technology companies.
Prompt:	Begin with 'Only by'.
Teacher's Answer:	Only by working closely with technology companies can governments fight online scams.

Part 4: Writing Task

Instructions:

1. Social media plays a big part in students' lives. Write ONE paragraph (about 60 words) giving your view on whether students should limit their use of social media.

2. Use ONE inversion and ONE relative clause.

Teacher's model answer: Social media is often blamed for distracting students, and every few months someone suggests banning it. A ban, however, treats the symptom, not the cause. Rarely do students have a more convenient way to exchange ideas and share learning resources, which textbooks alone can never provide. The real task is to teach responsible use, not to lock the apps away.